REDEFINING ROI: SEPARATING SIGNAL FROM NOISE IN THE AI SEARCH ERA



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TechB2B	Growth Tech
Home Services	Education
Real Estate	Careers
Auto	Lead Gen

Adjunct Professor

NORTHWESTERN UNIVERSITY

- **AI + Marketing Foundations**
- **Digital Transformation**

Industry Presence

iab.

The Media Insights & Engagement Conference

TMRE THE MARKET RESEARCH EVENT

Applied Marketing Analytics
The Peer-Reviewed Journal
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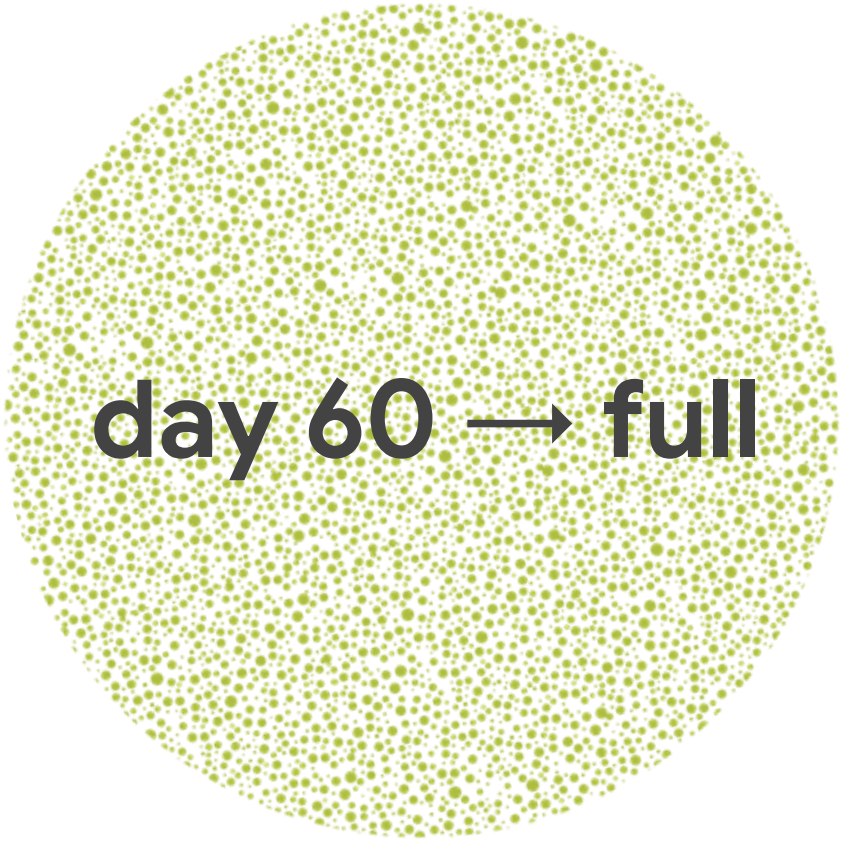

Imagine a massive pond
with one lily pad

day 2 → 2 lily pads

day 3 → 4 lily pads

day 4 → 8 lily pads

⋮


day 60 → full



How long to cover half of the pond?

59 days

Exponential growth bias



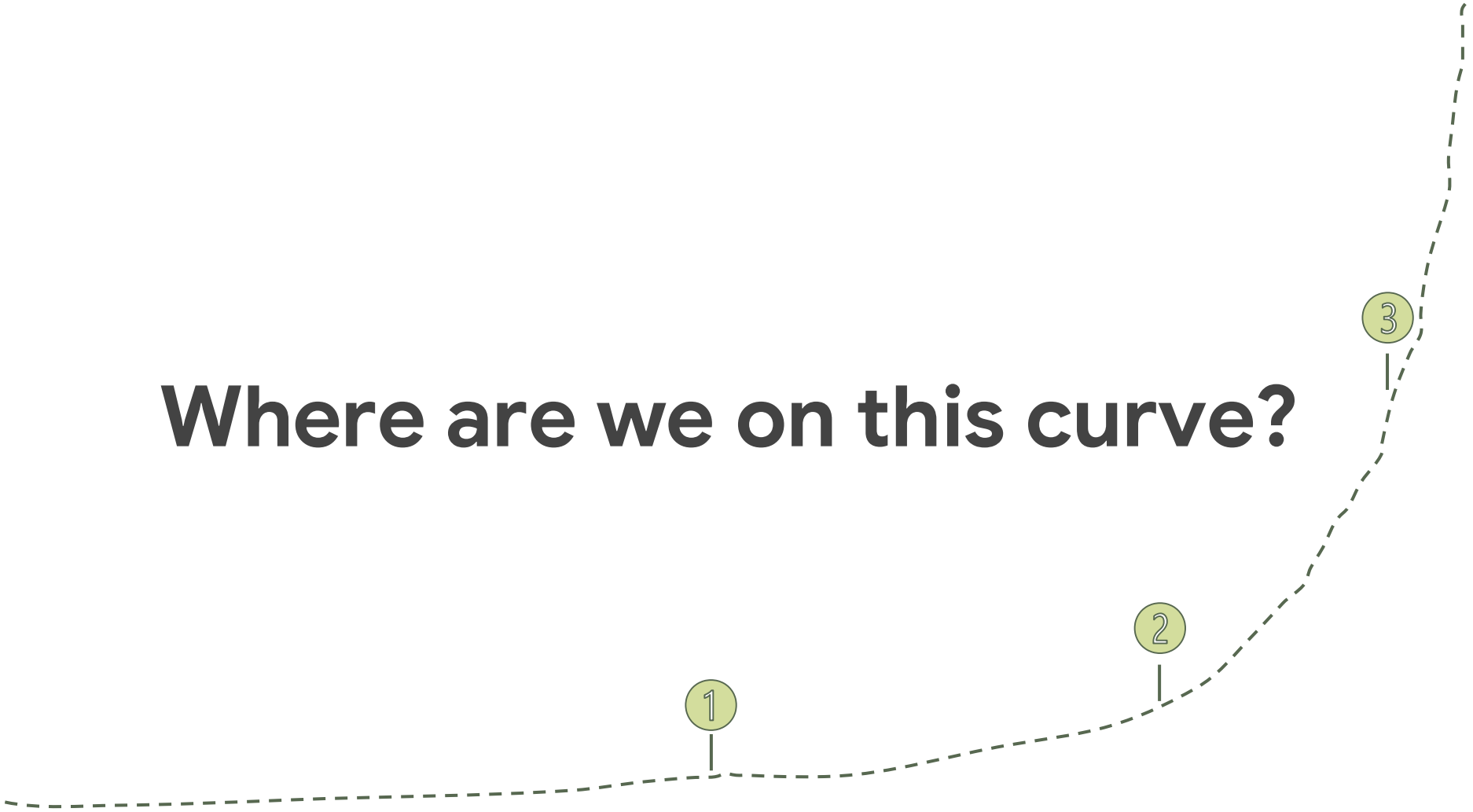
How long to cover 1% of the pond?

54 days



Exponential growth is non-intuitive for humans.

Where are we on this curve?



Where are we on this curve?





We are here



Evolving consumer behavior today

...means adapting how you evaluate success for the future

Consumer Behavior Shifts with AI

Changing Traffic Dynamics

Unit Economics & Monetization

A changing environment brings new questions

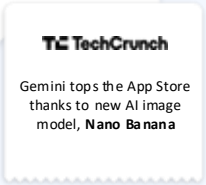
How is **consumer search behavior** changing in my industry?

What are the **implications** for my business?









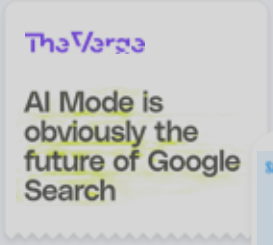


In this AI Era, how do I **redefine** what **success** looks like?

Is Search behavior for my brand and category changing because of AI?

How is **consumer search behavior** changing in my industry?

What are the **implications** for my business?

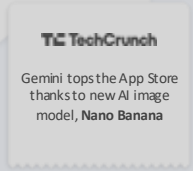






In this AI Era, how do I **redefine** what **success** looks like?





The old keyword search driven world

Category Searches

- Free word document
- project management platforms
- excel budget template
- text to speech software
- documents editor

Brand Searches

- Adobe acrobat
- docusign
- salesforce
- quickbooks online
- office 365

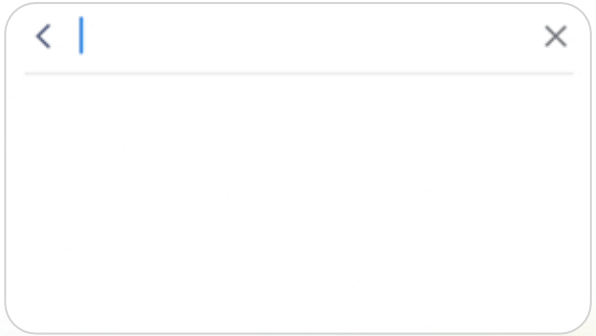
Your addressable market just expanded

Total Google Search queries reached an all-time high this year

AI OVERVIEWS

2.5 Billion

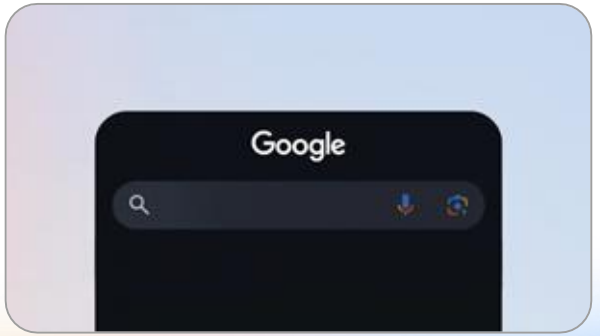
Monthly active users. Users are searching more often and reporting higher satisfaction.



AI MODE

1 Billion

Monthly active users. Queries are 3x longer and volume is doubling every quarter.



What new habits have we seen in 2026?

+30%

Brainstorming Queries

Consumers are using AI Mode for upper-funnel inspiration they used to find elsewhere.

+50%

Conversational Prompts

Users are abandoning short keywords to write detailed, 8+ word prompts.

+40%

Voice & Image

User search intent is diversifying away from purely text-based prompts toward multimodal input.

77%

Faster Decisions

Because AI does the heavy lifting, users are making confident purchase decisions faster.

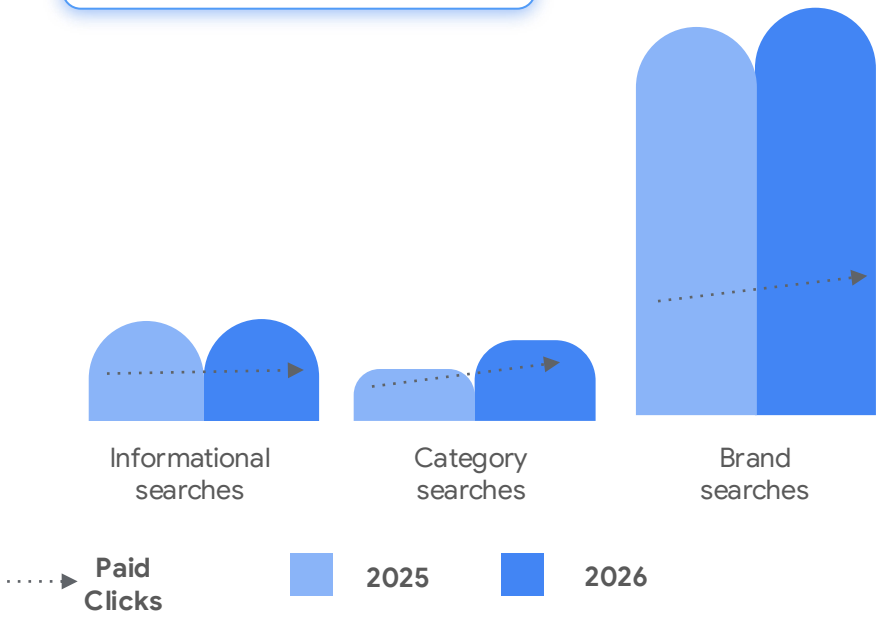


Is search behavior changing?

Business & Productivity Software Search Demand

For Illustrative Purposes

Informational searches maintained their share of total search



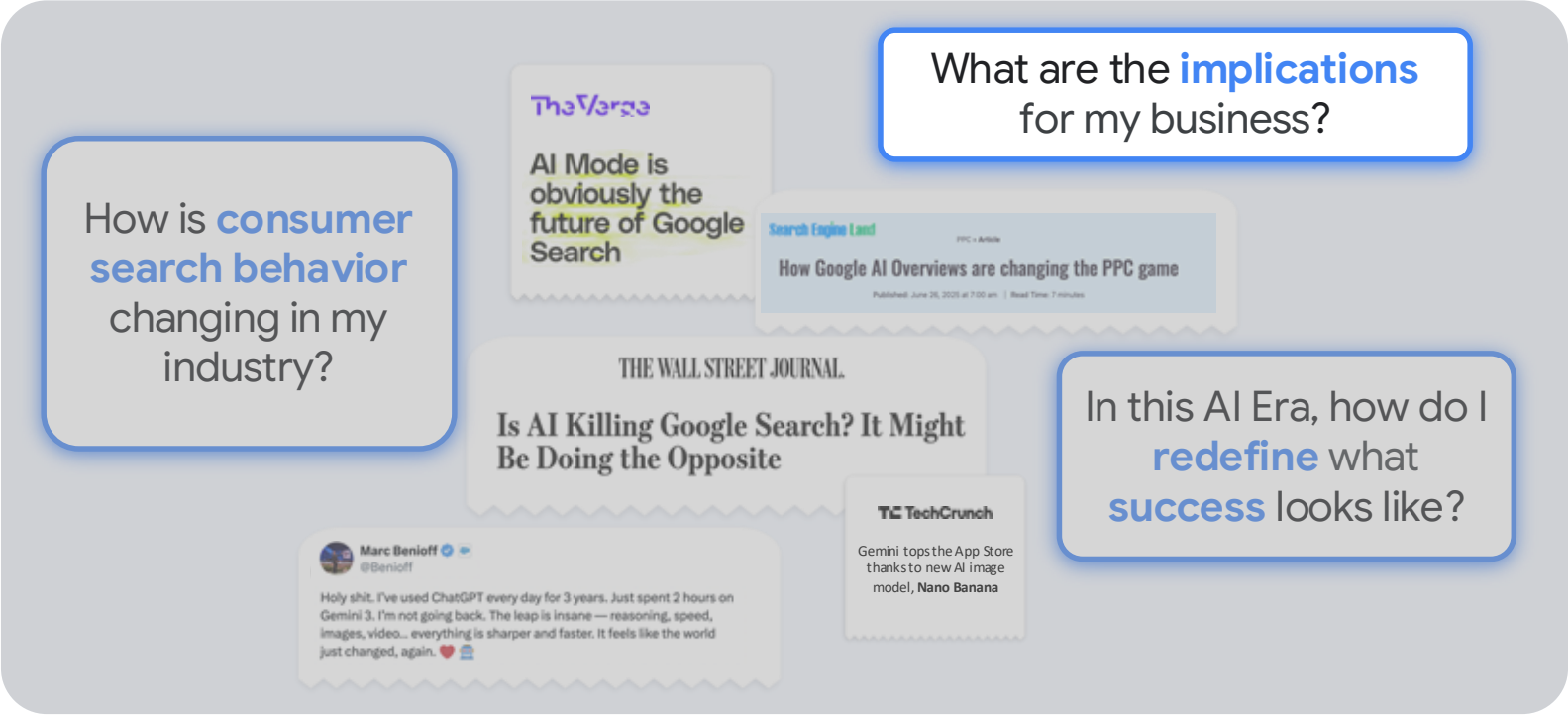
Jan-Apr 2026 vs. 2025, Analysis based on top 10K queries for Business & Productivity Software category

Deep-dive on Business & Productivity Software category

Key Takeaways

- **1 in 20 searches** in the category are Informational today though product specific searches make up the majority
- Informational searches are broadly either *task based* (how-to) or *product comparison related* (vs., best, etc.)
- Is your Search program set up to **capture** the opportunity?

What are the implications for my business?



Analyze

The WHAT

What are the implications for my business?

The HOW



Contextual Benchmarking

Benchmark your performance against industry/peers

What is my share of clicks on informational searches?



Analyze traffic shifts

Create custom channels within analytics tools to track external LLM traffic

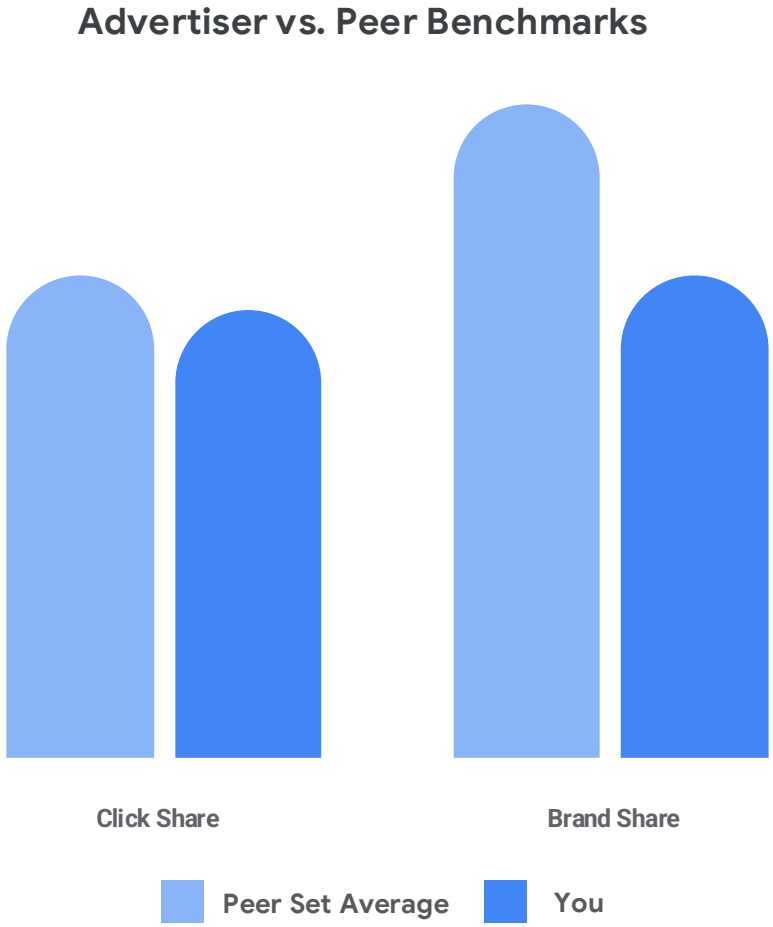
What percentage of my traffic is coming from Gemini, ChatGPT?



Capitalize with data strength

Compete more effectively with data as your differentiator

How do I ensure I get the best performance from media?

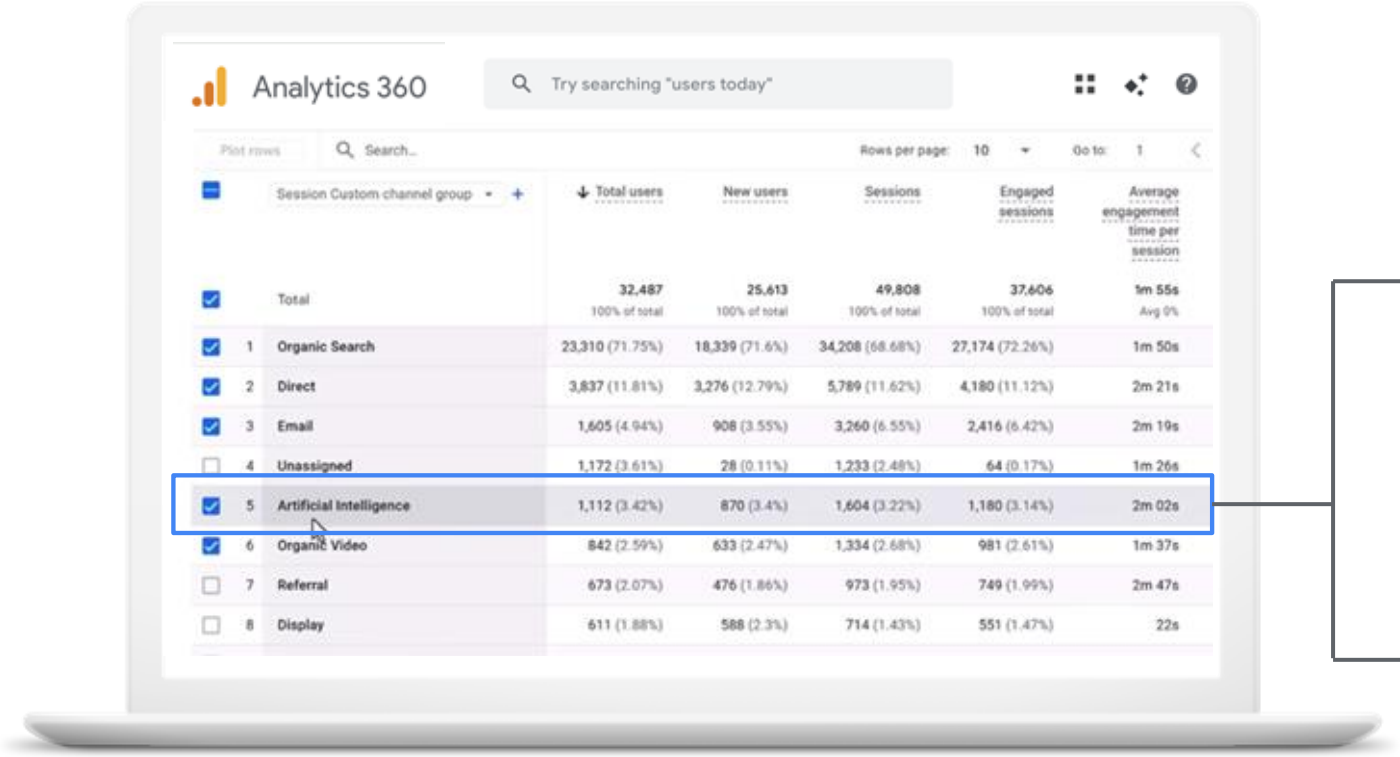


Contextual Benchmarking

Evolve benchmarking from time-based to peerset benchmarks

- **Click Share:** move to click share to establish share of traffic
- **Brand Share:** monitor Brand Search share to understand relevance & interest

Leverage Google Analytics to establish baselines for AI traffic



Understand which specific AI engines are delivering quality session with a traffic source group

Session Source
gemini.google.com
perplexity.ai
chatgpt.com
claude.ai
copilot.microsoft.com
perplexity
l.meta.ai
customgpt.ai

Proprietary + Confidential

A no-regrets action in the AI era is improving your Data Strength



Data Strength combines the best **technology** with the best **data** to reach **more of your customers, more efficiently.**

Improving Data Strength can drive 10-20% more tracked conversions

How do I redefine what success looks like?





Build systems to understand pace of change

The WHAT

In this AI Era, how do I redefine what success looks like?

The HOW

Learning Agenda

	Learning Question	Recommended KPI
Consumer Behavior Shifts with AI 	• How has the consumer **behavior shifted** for my industry? • How has my **Brand Share of Search** changed over time? • Am I meeting **evolved consumer expectations**?	• Informational Searches YoY • Brand Share of Search • Net Promoter Score
Changing Traffic Dynamics 	• Are we effectively **capturing all relevant traffic**? • What is my volume and engagement of **'AI Traffic'**?	• Clickshare • Engaged Traffic • AI Traffic Share
Unit Economics / Monetization 	• What key **UX opportunities** to increase conversion rates? • What **signals** (conversion, value) to drive better outcomes?	• Conversion Rates • ROAS

Recommended Signals for the AI Search Era

Consumer Behavior Shifts with AI

*How is AI evolving **consumer behaviors;** am I meeting their **expectations***

- **Informational Search Growth** (for my Category)
- **Brand Demand** (peerset benchmark)
- **Net Promoter Score** (am I meeting consumer expectations)

Changing Traffic Dynamics

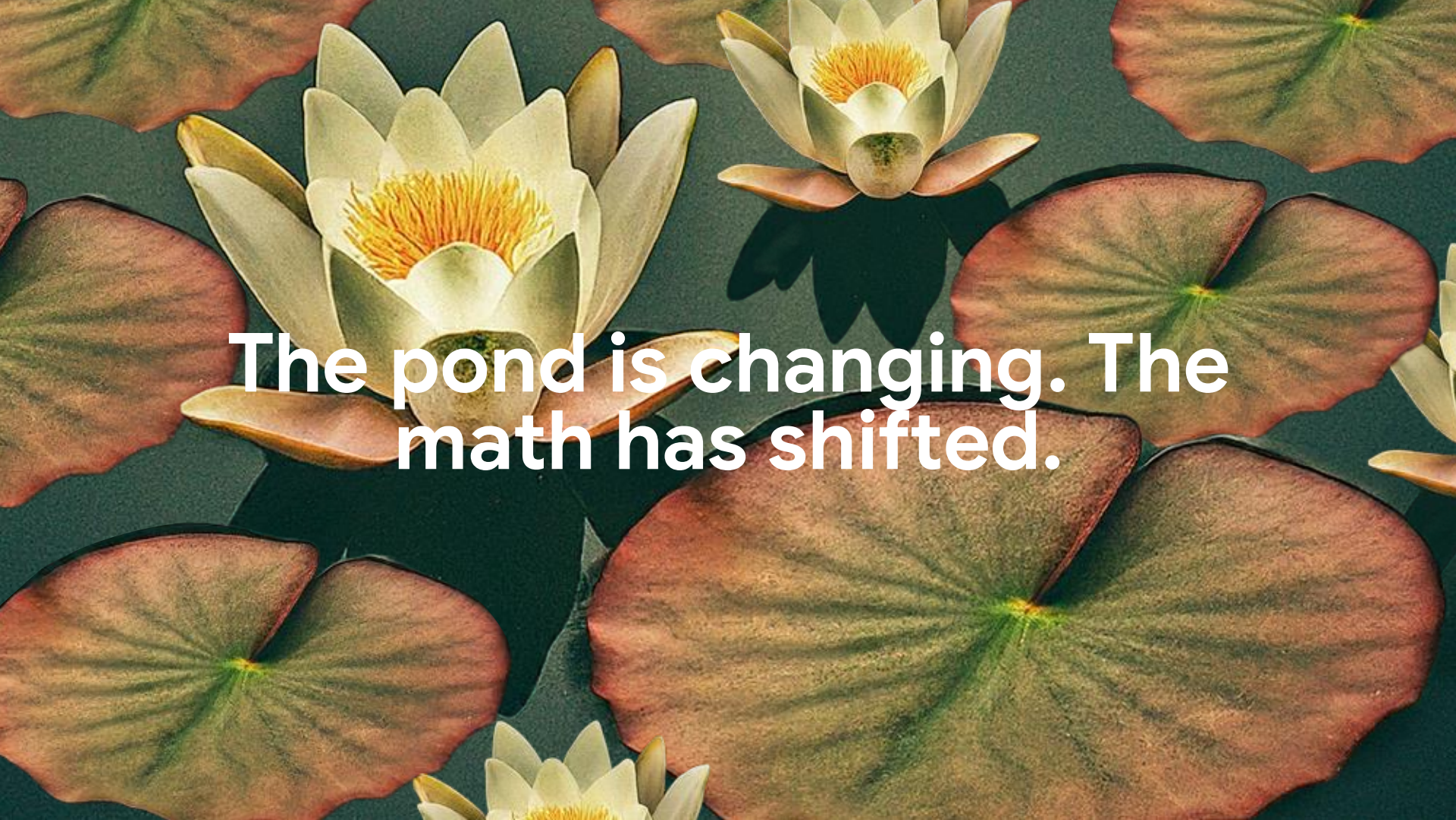
*As a result, how is my **traffic mix** changing*

- **Quality Traffic** (Engaged Session, Bounce rates)
- **Click Share** (Share of available traffic)
- **AI Traffic / AEO / GEO** (% of AI driven traffic)

Unit Economics / Monetization

*Are we **monetizing traffic** to the fullest extent*

- **Conversion Rate** (am I converting my traffic)
- **MQL -> SQL Conversion** (is lead flow maximizing throughput)
- **pLTV** (am I maximizing Lead Value)


The pond is changing. The math has shifted.

MAICON FORWARD

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THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.